

Coaching an Autistic Person at Every Age

The cumulative guide for coaches, PE teachers & activity leaders — across the whole autistic lifespan, from toddler classes to gentle activity for older adults. *An extended reference sheet; pair it with the single-age quick guides.*

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a person's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Movement and shared activity are genuinely protective — for mood, confidence, regulation and connection — yet autistic people are, on average, **less active than peers**, not from lack of interest but from barriers in the environment. Whatever the age of the person you coach, the evidence is clear on what helps: predictable routines, sensory-friendly spaces, good relationships, a strengths-based and game-based approach, and playing to deep focus. Reframe success at every age: the goal is a person who **wants to come back next time**.

What helps at every age

- **Predictable routine** — same warm-up, same structure, advance notice of changes; consistency lowers the entry cost.
- **Show, then say** — visual demonstration beats a speech; **one instruction at a time** in clear language.
- **Lower sensory load** — quieter spaces, fewer sudden sounds (hand signals, quiet claps), warning before whistles/buzzers; allow ear-defenders.
- **Play to focus and interest** — single-skill, game-form drills; a defined role; let deep concentration run.
- **Build the relationship first** — a person who trusts you will push through more; celebrate effort, not just results.
- **Have an overload plan** — an agreed quiet corner and a signal to step out, no questions asked.
- **Read withdrawal as a spent budget** — a drop-off or a meltdown usually means the load was too high, not lost interest; lower the load and they'll usually come back.

What to avoid at every age

- Surprise changes, loud "motivational" pressure, or "tough love" that shames a shutdown.
- Forcing eye contact, group socials or huddles with no opt-out; stopping stimming/movement.
- Equating a masked session, a quiet routine or a withdrawal with "not trying."
- Over-scheduling or "making up" missed sessions when they're already depleted — rest and a lighter load bring them back faster than extra pressure.

Quick notes by life stage

Toddlers / pre-school (2-5)

Same routine every session; show, don't just tell; one short instruction at a time; lower sudden noise. At this age the goal is a child who *wants to come back next week*.

Primary school (6-11)

Predictable warm-up/cool-down as transition ramps; scheduled, specific drink/rest breaks (interoception); a defined role and choice. Individual sports often suit; team sports work if the social load is managed.

Adolescence (12-18)

Your club can be the safest hour of their week. Watch for burnout; rest and reduced load are recovery. Give a clear role and use the interest; have an overload plan.

University / college (18-25)

Share the plan in advance; offer low-sensory, low-pressure socials; never make initiations mandatory. Keep membership flexible for burnout recovery.

Working adults

Offer written plans and predictable structure; respect headphones, quiet and routine as regulation; play to depth. A flexible, low-demand membership helps through hard patches.

Parents (in parent-and-child or family groups)

Share the plan in advance; lower the sensory load; offer low-pressure ways to join. Keep attendance flexible — many carry a high burnout load.

Older adults (60+)

Predictable format, quieter venues, defined pace; welcome the interest and expertise; account for hearing/vision loss. Gentle, structured activity is a lifeline against isolation and inactivity.

High-support (any age, adapted/sensory activity)

Pain and overload first for any new distress; predictable, sensory-kind, interest-led activity; allow stimming and movement; a calm overload plan. Focus on wellbeing and confidence, not performance.

Cross-cutting: what every coach needs to know

The environment is usually the barrier, not the person — predictable, sensory-friendly, relationship-led settings unlock participation. **Autistic inertia** means starting, stopping and switching cost energy — build in ramps and warnings. **Interoception** differences mean the person may not flag thirst, heat or fatigue — schedule specific check-ins. **Burnout hides behind a competent exterior**, especially in girls and women — take withdrawal and reduced tolerance seriously. **Camouflaging is exhausting** — keep social optional and low-pressure. Reframe success: wellbeing and confidence first, performance second.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Raymaker et al. (2020, burnout); Pearson & Rose (2021, masking); Kelly Mahler (2024, interoception); Klein et al. (2024, aging). Full citations are in the source drafts.